

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

This month in ALT:

In Backtalk, we speak with Kartik Bakshi, the country manager for India at Belkin. Then head over to Geek-Key to read up on Superhero Weaknesses. Then, in Infoporn, take a look at some of the named galaxies we've discovered.



Giant strikes

Find out all about the most dangerous piece of playground equipment ever, the giant stride, that swung kids all over the place, left them gashed and caused all kinds of injuries. They were banned or removed from playgrounds, and earned the monicker "giant strikes".

<http://dgit.in/giantstrikes>

WHAT'S NEW

Insects equipped with body armour

Leaf-footed bugs have legs that perform many roles. They are shaped and coloured to resemble leaves, and provide camouflage. They come in a variety of shapes and sizes, and form powerful weapons for two competitive males to fight over a breeding opportunity. Among the various species of the bugs, the number of spikes on the legs and their arrangement leads to a range of weaponised leg designs, much like the variety of swords in an armoury. It was hypothesized that the winner of a fight between two competing males is the one that inflicts the most damage, but this simple enough theory had not been experimentally verified, until now. Researchers outfitted the



leaf-foot bugs with leather padding on their wings and made them fight, giving the bugs a +2 to armour class. Those with

increased protection won the fight as predicted. Those that had a similar amount of padding in other places did not benefit. The researchers then went on to study which of the weaponised leg designs dealt the most damage. What they found was that some weapon shapes were better than others at inflicting damage, but at the same time, there were different solutions that caused the same amount of damage. <http://dgit.in/bugbattle>

Cassandra of the digital age

The internet has rewired our brains, and one prophet called it, but the warnings went unheeded. Michael Goldhaber has predicted a number of aspects about the information age including a surge in consumption of reality TV, aggravated shamelessness in politics, terrorists using social media, influencer culture, and oversharing. Most of these were realised by Goldhaber in the 80s, but these predictions were not



widely believed or accepted at that time. Goldhaber has also written a feature in Wired in 1997 called Attention Shoppers!, as well a seminal book in that

same year called "The attention economy and the net", in which he outlined how the world would move to an attention economy instead of a money based one. It was then that he had described the relentless pressure that creators on YouTube, Instagram, Twitch and Pateron are feeling now. One other concern that he has identified, is that if a healthy democracy can exist alongside the information economy at all. <http://dgit.in/mgbrainwire>



What are lichen?

A homeschooled forest ranger has managed to discover something fundamental about lichen and prove all biology textbooks wrong. Lichen is not made up of two organisms, an alga and a fungi, but instead made up of three, a second type of fungus was hiding in plain sight.

<http://dgit.in/tpguy>



The plight of sperms

Researchers are tracking falling sperm counts globally, not just among humans, but many animal species as well. They have identified a new class of chemicals called endocrine disruptors in plastics, foods, pesticides, and cosmetics as the cause of the crisis.

<http://dgit.in/dedsperm>



How to be a genius?

A new book gives a glimpse inside the most brilliant minds in history, uncovering their secret habits, and hidden lessons of geniuses such as Mozart, Leonardo da Vinci and Queen Elizabeth I, called The Hidden Habits of Genius. The author also offers a course on the subject.

<http://dgit.in/geniusacco>